MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 1: Poetry from Milton to the Pre-Romantics

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Reading poetry across this period means comparing forms of authority, satire, emotion, and imagination without turning historical labels into rigid rules.

Start with a picture

Several writers use different tools to shape a judgement: an epic voice, a pointed couplet, a memorable song, an unanswered question. A critical comparison explains what each tool makes possible.

1. Begin with the speaking position

Distinguish narrator, character, lyric speaker, and satirist. Satan’s rhetoric is not identical to Milton’s narrative judgement. A mock praise in Dryden can mean the opposite of an ordinary compliment. Burns’s lyric speaker is a crafted voice even where the song feels intimate.

This distinction prevents a common error: treating every memorable statement as the author’s own direct belief.

2. Form and scale

Milton’s blank verse supports extended syntax and epic movement. Dryden’s and Pope’s couplets can intensify balance, contrast, and judgement. Burns’s song form makes feeling repeatable, while Blake’s repeated questions organise trust or uncertainty.

Do not assume one formal device always has one effect. Explain its role in the actual passage.

3. Epic and mock epic

The relation between style and subject is crucial. Elevated language can grant an action apparent greatness; mock epic makes that grant unstable. A reader must ask which values are being tested and whether the subject’s smaller social scale makes its ethical stakes negligible.

Belinda’s treatment, for example, should not disappear merely because Pope uses an inflated style.

4. Changing emphases

Neoclassical, transitional, and pre-Romantic are critical labels. Order, feeling, wit, nature, religion, and imagination coexist within the period. Burns's relation to song and Blake's symbolic questioning qualify any account of an exclusively rational eighteenth century.

The course asks for a poet called the first of the Romantics. Treat such titles as historical critical shorthand whose answer may depend on the particular survey, not an uncontested fact establishing one inventor of Romanticism.

5. Comparing innocence and experience

The Lamb offers a trusting answer; The Tyger sustains questions about fierce creative power. Neither needs to be reduced to a fixed moral diagram. Their relation is a good example of how apparently simple language can carry an unresolved philosophical problem.

6. An exam method

Choose a shared question—authority, value, time, creation, or social judgement. Compare two particular techniques rather than providing separate biographies. Include the difference between a poem's claim and the limits the poem exposes.

Quick check

1. Are wit and feeling opposites? **No.**
2. Is every pre-Romantic poet alike? **No.**
3. Does naming a metre explain its effect? **Not until connected with a passage.**

Build an exam answer

1. State the limits of period labels.
2. Distinguish speakers and frames.
3. Compare epic and mock-epic techniques.
4. Use Burns or Blake to test reason/feeling binaries.
5. Conclude through a specific qualified judgement.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not turn "first Romantic" or another survey title into a universal factual ranking.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How can a critical comparison avoid oversimplifying the poetry of the period?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

A critical comparison needs historical categories but must test them through particular works. The familiar contrast between neoclassical order and Romantic feeling becomes misleading if it denies emotional intensity to satire or formal craft to song. Poems create their effects through arrangements of voice, image, and argument, not through a period label alone.

The distinction between a speaker and a narrator is equally important. Satan’s attractive rhetoric does not settle the moral position of Paradise Lost, while Mac Flecknoe’s ceremonial praise is structured as an attack. Both require readers to interpret a distance between what is said and the frame that makes it meaningful.

Burns and Blake demonstrate other relations between surface simplicity and thought. Musical repetition sustains a declaration of affection, whereas repeated questioning can make certainty unavailable. These formal differences help explain changing emphases without pretending that a new age instantly replaces the old.

A strong answer therefore chooses a focused question, analyses paired details, and qualifies any large generalisation. History becomes more useful when it explains a tension than when it acts as a label placed over the poem.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. How does Dryden create a mock-heroic atmosphere?
2. What is another term for Pre-Romantic poetry?
3. Name some of the important poets of the Pre-Romantic era.
4. Which poet is regarded as “the first of the romantics”?
5. What are the two works by William Blake which deal with opposite themes? Make a contrastive analysis of them.